

HAMPI

AN INTERLUDE OF POETIC CHARMS AND RUSTIC HIGHS

Set in an incredible boulder-strewn landscape along the banks of the Tungabhadra River, Hampi was the capital city of the mighty Vijayanagara Empire. The first sight to welcome visitors to Hampi will be the many ancient structures among the plantations and greenery; all in the backdrop of countless boulders of various sizes and shapes as far as the eye can see.

Founded by Harihara and Bukka in 1336, it fell to the rulers of the Deccan in 1565. The once proud city of victory is now a city of desolation. However, the ruins of these historical monuments have withstood the ravages of man and time, and still evoke memories of the grandeur of a bygone era.

Classified as a World Heritage Site by UNESCO, this historic town is also the "World's Largest Open-air Museum" and covers an area of nearly 29 sq. km. Vijayanagara Empire at its peak was very prosperous and was believed to be larger than Rome with palaces grander than those in Lisbon. *"The city is such that the pupil of the eye has never seen a place like it, and the ear of intelligence has never been informed that there existed anything to equal it in the world"*, marvelled the 15th century Persian ambassador Abdul Razaak. There were opulent palaces, marvelous temples, massive fortifications, baths, markets, aquaducts, pavilions, stables for royal elephants, and elegantly carved pillars. This was a city whose merchants traded in diamonds, pearls, horses, fine silks and brocades.

WHAT TO SEE

Vijaya Vittala Temple

The Vijaya Vittala Temple is Hampi's crowning glory. Well-known for its exceptional architecture and unmatched craftsmanship, the Vijaya Vittala Temple exemplifies the Vijayanagara Empire at the peak of its glory. Dedicated to Lord Vishnu in the form of Vittala, the main structure features a 100-pillared Sabha Mantapa and a Kalyana Mantapa.

Another attraction, the Dancing Hall, features the most fascinating and famous part of the temple—the 56 musical pillars that resonate to the seven musical notes of the Indian musical scale and musical instruments, when tapped. It's a magnificent demonstration of the Vijayanagara artisans' mastery over the stone carving craft as well as of the science of acoustics. However, at present visitors are not permitted to tap the pillars.

The magnificent Stone Chariot in front of the temple, is in itself a miniature temple, dedicated to Garuda, Lord Vishnu's vehicle and is believed to be carved out of a single rock.

Virupaksha Temple

One of the oldest temples in Hampi, the Virupaksha Temple is an important pilgrimage centre for the worshippers of Lord Shiva and his consort Pampa Devi. One of the few temples in Hampi in active worship, it has an imposing Gopura (tower) and at 165 ft, the nine storey tower is one of the highest in Karnataka.

One of the main attractions here is the ornate central Mantapa (pavilion) with paintings covering the ceiling depicting the epics and puranas and a unique three-faced Nandi image just as you enter the temple. The marriage of Lord Shiva and Goddess Pampa is still recreated annually in the colourful Kalyana Mantapa here. One of the earliest examples of a pinhole camera can be seen here with the inverted image of the main gopura, projected on the wall of a side passage around the shrine. The temple is a treasure trove of history as parts of it predate even the Vijayanagara Empire.



VIRUPAKSHA TEMPLE

GETTING THERE

BY ROAD:
Hospet 12 Km | Hubballi 170 Km | Bengaluru 340 Km

BY RAIL:
Hospet 12 Km | Hubballi 170 Km

BY AIR:
Vijayanagar (Torangallu) 37 km | Hubballi 170 Km | Bengaluru 360 Km | Hyderabad 379 Km



VIJAYA VITTALA TEMPLE